domestic politics and religion, Kashmiri Pandits were targeted as being the 'others' who did not support the freedom movement or, worse, were informers of the Indian armed forces. Militant groups placed advertisements in Urdu newspapers with a deadline to leave the Valley and hit-list notices were stuck on people's gates. The army was called in and curfews were put in place, but the hostile sentiment in the Valley overwhelmed both, the law-keeping forces and the Kashmiri Pandits. In his memoir about the exodus, Rahul Pandita describes his feelings as a young child in 1990:[69]

> I can't fathom why all this is happening. If the Kashmiris are demanding Azadi, why do the Pandits have to be killed? Why do we have to leave our house, where I play freely, and ride my cycle, and exchange comics with my friends? How is the burning of a temple or molesting a Pandit lady on the road going to help in the cause of Azadi?

In early 1990, thousands of Kashmiris left their homes for Jammu through the only link road—the Jawahar Tunnel—ironically named after the first prime minister of India and arguably the most famous Kashmiri Pandit. The poorest and those from rural areas filled the refugee camps while the better-off stayed in hotels, houses of relatives, rented rooms or moved to Delhi and beyond.[70] As per the relief commissioner, there were over 20,000 people in sixteen migrant camps in Jammu.[71] The migrant camps initially comprised cloth tents and later transformed into one-room tenements that housed four to five members.[72] They were locally referred to as *kabutarkhana*s (pigeon-cages). Some people in the refugee camps remained unemployed for a long time, supported by salaries and pensions that were promised before the exodus. Since the migrants had not sold their Kashmiri houses, expecting to return eventually, a large number of properties were kept in the care of trusted Muslim friends and neighbours. But the security situation in Kashmir remained fragile for the next two decades with heavy militarization, as a result of which most Kashmiri Pandits did not return home. In fact, many Kashmiri Muslims also began migrating seeking jobs and education outside the Valley. Some Kashmiris moved on to build new lives, but always carried the burden of loss and longing. A study conducted in Delhi found Kashmiri Pandits reported lower life satisfaction levels than